



Promising talents: With young stars like Divya Deshmukh eyeing GM titles and a new generation waiting in the wings, the future of Indian chess is in safe hands. MICHAŁ WALUSZA/FIDE

individual gold medals on Boards 3 and 4. Unlike the Open section, the women's category was fiercely contested. Top-seeded India got off to a smooth start, defeating Jamaica in the opening round before comfortably dispatching European powerhouses Czechia, Switzerland, and France in the following rounds.

Round five presented a tougher challenge in Kazakhstan. On the top board, Harika Dronavalli squandered a winning position with Black in a Petrov Defense against Bibisara Assaubayeva, dropping her second point in four games. But R. Vaishali and Vantika came to the rescue, securing crucial wins, while Divya's draw ensured India remained unbeaten.

Vantika, Divya, and Vaishali each secured a victory in the next two rounds against strong Armenian and Georgian teams. India didn't lose a single game on any board and looked poised to cruise to the top.

India's juggernaut came to a halt

against Poland, where Harika suffered her third loss and Vaishali also fell, creating a three-way tie at the top with Poland and Kazakhstan. The race for gold seemed to slip away after a 2-2 draw against the USA in the ninth round, which pushed India into second place behind Kazakhstan. Harika, who was rested for the USA clash as Tania Sachdev took the last board, was reinstated for the crucial match against China. Only a win would keep the team's gold hopes alive — and it delivered. Just like the men, three boards ended in draws, while Divya secured a decisive victory, giving the women's team a crucial boost.

India entered the final round tied with Kazakhstan, knowing that even a win might not guarantee gold. But as it had done throughout the tournament, India delivered when it mattered most, overwhelming Azerbaijan 3.5-1.5 to make a strong case for the title. The final nail in the coffin for Kazakhstan came from USA, which held it to a 2-2 draw, clearing the path for India to clinch its first-ever women's chess Olympiad gold in style.

In a rare departure from its usually reserved nature, the team celebrated with unbridled joy.

Gukesh and Tania's playful re-enactment of Ric Flair's iconic 'trophy walk' celebration perfectly captured the camaraderie and close-knit spirit of the squad.

This team bond, as Srinath emphasised, was key to its success. "There's no exact formula that guarantees success every time, but good team bonding increases the probability of better results. Being in a positive space helps you play better."

What makes this triumph even more remarkable is the age of the Indian contingent — six out of 10 players are under 23, with an average age of less than 20 among the four individual gold medallists.

Gukesh, in particular, solidified his status as one of India's leading chess stars, with eight wins on the top board, being the only player to cross a 3000 rating performance mark. His back-to-back gold medals, echoing his performance from 2022, leave little doubt about his ability to reign at the top. Arjun's rise to World No. 3 and Gukesh's close pursuit at No. 5, both nearing the elite 2800-rating mark, have been equally heart-warming. With young stars like Divya and Vantika eyeing GM titles and a new generation waiting in the